The Unknown Longevity and Influence of Religion and Governance

Introduction

Nations worldwide have integrated religious and political systems, most commonly in the Middle East and Central Asia. The Iranian Revolution, Soviet invasion of Afghanistan, and the Saudi Arabia Grand Mosque takeover in 1979 demonstrate how religious ideologies influence politics and contribute to modern terrorism today (Chentouh, 2026). Official Islam (OI) is implemented in Kyrgyzstan, affecting individuals' political trust and religiosity nationwide (Jones & Nisar, 2026). Secular states in other regions are also shaped by religious influence in various ways, such as religious organizations' participation in Taiwan's political system and the religious backlash that divided the United States along partisan lines after the events of January 6th (Campbell & Layman, 2026; Jiang, 2026). Despite religion's influence on politics, there isn't enough literature on how that influence unfolds over time. How long does religion's political influence last within a society? In this paper, I test two hypotheses to answer the research question: modernization/secularization decreases religion's influence over time (H1), and the institutionalization of a religion strengthens its political system and allows it to continue over time (H2).

H1: Modernization/Secularization Decreases Religion's Political Influence Over Time

Religiosity may decrease across generations, but religion's decline in certain countries may depend on context (Stolz et al., 2025). If religious decline varies by context, traditionally Muslim societies offer clear examples. Iran, Tunisia, Turkey, Iraq, and Egypt report positive differences, where younger individuals are less religious than previous generations, but that does not mean the entire world is becoming less religious in the short term (Stolz et al., 2025). In the short to medium term, religiosity could grow globally as religious nations make up a larger share of the global population, but if secularism continues, the world will see a long-term decrease in religiosity (Stolz et al., 2025).

To further challenge the hypothesis, I use historical data to show that religious influence declines in four waves of expansion, secularization, and revival, rather than in a clear linear direction. In Western Europe, the first wave came from forced conversions by higher authorities, such as King Clovis' conversion in 486 AD, who enforced his new religion through power, hierarchy, war, compulsion, and violence (Bruce, 2011). The second wave was the influence of friars in cities and towns, which divided people into the deeply religious and the less committed (Bruce, 2011). Third, the sixteenth-century Protestant Reformation focused on making ordinary people more devoted to religion rather than the clerics and monks (Bruce, 2011). Fourth, Evangelical and Pietist revivals emerged as religious enthusiasm, became institutionalized, and began to decline over time (Bruce, 2011). Across these four waves, religious influence rose and fell for more than a thousand years, suggesting that secularization may be cyclical rather than a slow, permanent decline (Bruce, 2011).

One way to counter this hypothesis is to analyze studies linking religious attendance and political participation in secular societies. Specifically, Jiang (2022) suggests that the widespread assumption that religion's influence on political participation is declining in increasingly secular societies is overstated. To analyze the author's findings, I utilize their first figure, which is based on cross-sectional data from the Australian Election Study (AES). The author's results demonstrate that 17.6 percent regularly attended religious services in 1987, down to 10 percent

by 2019; religious belonging was around 80 percent and fell to nearly 60 percent by 2019; and those with no religion rose from 12.5 percent to 37.2 percent (Jiang, 2022).

Furthermore, religious belief and practice differ because one reflects a person's faith, while the other involves religious activities. Huber and Mohamed (2023) demonstrate why secularism can still coexist with religion in electoral politics. I use the fourth figure in their article, which tests the association between religiosity and electoral participation. Their results suggest that religious belief is more closely associated with policy preferences, while religious participation is more closely linked to political participation (Huber & Mohamed, 2023).

H2: Religious Institutions in Politics Persist Over Time

To support this hypothesis, religious institutions depend on their continued political involvement to sustain their lifespan. Religious institutions are path-dependent once included in law and political society, especially in highly secular contexts (Golan-Nadir & Smith, 2026). Prior to the American Revolution, the "Blue Laws" concept originated in the Jamestown Legislative Assembly in the 17th century, which voted to make Church Attendance mandatory on Sundays, and it was widely legislated across the thirteen colonies (Golan-Nadir & Smith, 2026). Although this law has religious origins, it remained common in many states until the 19th century and still appears in some state legislation (Golan-Nadir & Smith, 2026). These demonstrate that even in democratic societies, especially in the West such as the United States, there is some sort of religious influence on politics, even though they are secular nations.

Moreover, I use a table from Barro and McCleary (2005), which presents data on state religion in 1900, 1970, and 2000. State-religion status in 1900 strongly predicts state religion status in 1970 and 2000, with many countries remaining unchanged. 58 had a state religion across all three periods. 22 had a Muslim state religion, 21 had a Catholic state religion, and 72 did not have a state religion in any of the three periods; the rest went through periods of continuation, abolition, or re-institution (Barro & McCleary, 2005). These examples show that state religion has changed across nations in the past, and some went through continuation, abolition, or re-institution of the religious state that exists today.

In addition, some nations establish a state religion to the point that it becomes a religious monopoly, gains political power, and can shape policy. Rahman states three key findings in her research. First, the interference of the state and religion will most likely establish a process that helps a nation with a state religion gain political influence that can be utilized to discriminate against religious minorities (Rahman, 2013). Second, with this process, once state involvement has taken place, Muslim-majority status itself is not associated with higher discrimination (Rahman, 2013). Third, Muslim-majority nations have a higher likelihood of having an established religion that provides economic and political benefits than other states, which can increase religious influence over government laws (Rahman, 2013).

Conclusion

Overall, the literature shows that religion's political influence is not linear or confined to a single timeline. Secularization and modernization may weaken its social basis, while religious institutionalization within politics can maintain religious political influence through laws and other political substructures. These can provide the basis for future research on whether religious political influence continues or declines over time.

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